



Body of lacquered copper

Dispenser nozzle

Cutoff shutter lever

Compound rammer to force bullet into chamber

▲ POWDER FLASK

By the 1860s, the traditional powder horn had given way to the flask, which incorporated a dispenser for a measured amount of powder as its spout. Most were ornamented with hunting or martial scenes.



Foresight

Muzzle

Compound rammer lever

Two bullets can be cast at once

Bullet mold handle

▼ AMMUNITION

As in all percussion revolvers, powder and projectile (bullet or ball) were loaded at the muzzle of each chamber in turn, before a percussion cap was placed over an external nipple at the rear of each chamber. Measured cap amounts of powder and projectile were made into simple cartridges with combustible cases made of fine animal membrane. The user placed each cartridge into the muzzle of a chamber, powder charge first, with the bullet facing outward. The cartridge case was crushed when seated home in the chamber by the compound rammer—a small press permanently attached to the revolver.



Excess lead sheared by blade when bullet was set



▲ LEAD BULLETS

By 1861, the cylindro-ogival form (above) had replaced the ball to become the standard shape for both rifle and pistol bullets (see pp. 306–07). They were still being made from pure lead, without the addition of a hardening agent such as antimony.

► BULLET MOLD

Even though calibers had by now become standardized, it was still almost unheard-of to buy loose bullets. Instead, one bought a bar of lead and made one's own bullets, using the mold supplied with the pistol.